DRAFT

Leave Early When Evacuation Is Possible

Leaving early gives you more time and helps keep routes open for emergency responders. Match your action to the most urgent condition below—and always follow current instructions from authorized local officials.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Terminology and legal authority differ by jurisdiction. “Warning,” “advisory,” “order,” zone names, and readiness levels may not mean the same thing everywhere. The issuing authority's instructions—not the headings on this handout—control. Verify local terms, zones, alert providers, routes, shelters, and phone numbers before publication.

1. WARNING OR ADVISORY: GET READY TO LEAVE

Conditions may worsen or officials may recommend that you prepare. Treat the time as an opportunity to act—not a promise that another message will arrive.

1. **Monitor official channels.** Check who issued the message, its time, the affected area, and what action it requests. Keep more than one alert method available.
2. **Notify the household and support network.** Tell everyone the current plan, including caregivers and people who may need transportation, mobility, communication, language, medical, or animal assistance. Do not send anyone into danger.
3. **Load essential items now.** Take go-bags, medicines, medical and mobility equipment, identification, keys, phones and chargers, water, protective clothing, and essential animal supplies. Keep the vehicle pointed toward the exit if it is safe to do so.
4. **Reassess transportation and destinations.** Confirm who is leaving, the vehicle or assistance needed, fuel or charging status, a primary and backup route, and more than one safe destination. Conditions, road closures, and shelter availability can change.
5. **Leave early if conditions threaten you.** People who need extra travel time, have animals or transportation constraints, or are uncomfortable waiting should consider leaving before an order, when officials permit and a safe route and destination are available.

EVS-003

Leave Early When Evacuation Is Possible — continued

2. EVACUATION ORDER OR DIRECTION: LEAVE NOW

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Do not wait to finish packing. Follow the authorized official's instructed route and destination. Use a different route or destination only if officials redirect you or the instructed path presents an immediate danger.

1. Take the people and animals with you who are present and ready. Take only essential items already at hand.

2. Use the instructed transportation, route, destination, and timing. Obey roadblocks and responder directions; do not take shortcuts into closed areas.

3. If you cannot evacuate as directed, contact the emergency or transportation-assistance service identified by local officials. If there is an immediate threat to life, call emergency services when safe and appropriate.

4. Continue monitoring official updates while traveling, without distracting the driver. Do not return until the responsible authority says the area is open.

3. IMMEDIATE THREAT: MOVE AWAY FROM DANGER

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

If life is in danger, do not wait for an alert, warning, or evacuation order. Move away from the danger immediately using the safest available direction. Conditions you can see, hear, smell, or feel may become life-threatening before an official message reaches you.

- Put distance and a protective barrier between you and the hazard. Do not enter smoke, moving floodwater, fire, a chemical release, damaged buildings, downed-wire areas, or another obvious danger to follow a planned route.
- Warn people immediately nearby if you can do so without delaying escape. Help children, people with access or functional needs, and animals only when you can do so without trapping yourself or others.
- Call emergency services when you are in a safer place and when calling is safe and appropriate. State your location, the threat, injuries, and anyone known to remain in danger; follow the call taker's instructions.
- Once clear, use official information to choose a safe destination and learn whether the area is closed. Do not go back into danger.

Leave Early When Evacuation Is Possible — continued

DO NOT DELAY FOR

- belongings beyond essentials already at hand;
- photographs or keepsakes;
- watering, covering, defending, or otherwise preparing property;
- searching for absent household members in an unsafe area — use the household communication plan and tell responders what you know; or
- television, radio, phone alerts, social media, neighbors, or other communication channel to agree.

ACT ON AUTHENTICATED INSTRUCTIONS OR AN IMMEDIATE THREAT.

FILL IN ONLY AFTER LOCAL VERIFICATION

◎ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

LOCAL INFORMATION — UNVERIFIED UNTIL CONFIRMED BY THE RESPONSIBLE LOCAL AUTHORITY

Local warning/readiness levels and meanings:

_____

_____

Evacuation zone name/number and official lookup method:

_____

Official alert provider(s) and enrollment address:

_____

Official public-information / evacuation-assistance phone number(s):

_____

Authority confirming these entries: _____
Representative and role: _____ **Date verified:** _____
Verification method: _____ **Binder reviewer:** _____

Leave Early When Evacuation Is Possible — continued

CONTINUE YOUR PLAN

- **EVS-001:** use the readiness checklist to confirm that your household plan and essential supplies are ready.
- **EVS-004:** use your two planned routes and destinations, unless officials direct otherwise.
- **EVS-005:** use your primary or backup transportation arrangement; never enter an unsafe area to search for someone.

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Evacuation” and “Alerts and Warnings”; FEMA, “Wireless Emergency Alerts” and “Planning Considerations for Evacuation and Shelter-in-Place”; CAL FIRE, “Ready, Set, Go!” Accessed September 25, 2026. Local details above intentionally remain unverified.